

Use the word 'write' in a conversation today, and you'll have everyone thinking you're talking about burning a CD. That's how commonplace CD-Writers are today. All and sundry ran out and bought one when their prices plummeted, because everyone wanted a cheap backup solution. From a backup of all your office documents, accounts sheets and e-mails to your favourite songs, movies and family pictures, all can be frozen in time on a little cheap disc. That's the beauty of a CD-Writer, its just so darn useful, and so darn cheap!

CD-Writers are commonplace now—who needs a CD-ROM drive when a CD-RW drive can read, write and rewrite, and only costs a little more! But wait, DVDs are popular too, and almost everyone wants one. So, *Viola!*, manufacturers come up with another Jack-of-all-trades drive—the combination drive. This drive can not only read, write and rewrite CDs, but also play DVDs. What else could one ask for? Confused? Don't worry, we plan on helping you decide on a drive, and make the drives sweat it out in our tests. After all, we're talking performance and money here!

Features

We received 11 CD-RW drives for the comparison tests. Since the number was quite considerable and the brands various, we checked out the features and package contents of each drive that came in.

The Asus CD-RW drive was packed to its gills—you name it, they gave it, from an extra data cable, to an audio cable to connect to legacy sound cards. All the other drives provided at least a CD-R and the CD-writing software. Plextor and Krypton disappointed us; Plextor provided only the Nero writing software and their proprietary PlexTools, with a quick installation guide and warranty card. Krypton

Speed, quality and deeds—all put to test in the battle of drives

The Write Fight

only provided an audio cable and the Nero CD burning software. Other manufacturers provided a CD-R and in some cases, a data cable and CD-RW as well. This made Plextor look bad, considering that it's a premium drive manufacturer.

Asus and MSI were the only drives that had two separate LEDs to indicate read and write. The MSI drive was a real looker, with a black front bezel and transparent buttons which also function as LEDs. Some drives had only a single-coloured LED to indicate both read and write, which is very misleading. If you're burning something and your sibling opens the drive or presses a button, instead of a CD with a back up of your valuable data, you end up with a coaster for your coffee mug.

We also checked the features that some of the drives provided while the other's missed out on, such as Mount Rainier (see box 'Jargon Buster'). All the drives were vertically mountable and thus the real meat of the competition lay in the performance tests, to which we move on next.

Performance

CD-Writers and re-writers

It was a well-fought and close competition, with some surprising results. We began with the Nero CD Speed and average transfer rate tests. We used an audio CD so that we could also get the DAE test results in one go. Most drives available today can read sub-channel data and audio, and also do EFM correction. The MSI drive's DAE test result shocked us. It scored 0. Surprised, we tested it again, and still got 0. This shows a big difference between the data on the CD and the data extracted from it—though when we used the drive to rip audio tracks to MP3 and WAV, and compared it to tracks ripped from other drives, we found no discernable difference.

The data transfer test also shocked us. The worst

